



Frustrations in Collaborative Working

Insights from institutional theory

Clare Rigg & Noreen O'Mahony

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Abstract

Qualitative evidence from an action research study is used to address the research question 'how can institutional context help explain frustrations within local collaborations?' This study of multi-agency collaboration for local economic strategy in Ireland finds that individual and organization actions at a local level are substantially shaped along paths structured by funding and performance management arrangements of multiple central government departments. The article concludes that any calls for greater collaboration at a local level will produce limited effects without a simultaneous scrutiny of cross-boundary working at the centre.

Key words

Collaboration, institutional theory, path dependency, embedded agency, institutional entrepreneurship, action research

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Clare Rigg and
Noreen O'Mahony

Clare Rigg

School of Business & Humanities
Institute of Technology Tralee
Co. Kerry
Ireland
E-mail: clare.rigg@staff.ittralee.ie

Noreen O'Mahony

School of Business & Humanities
Institute of Technology Tralee
Co. Kerry
Ireland
E-mail: noreen.omahony@research.ittralee.ie



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INTRODUCTION

In Ireland, County and City Development Boards (CDBs) were established in each of the thirty-four County and City Councils in 2000, as

the mechanism for local government, local development, the State agencies, and the social partners, to work out an agreed vision for their county or city ... (and) provide the framework within which all public and local development services will be implemented at local level. (Interdepartmental Task Force on the Integration of Local Government and Local Development Systems, 2000: i)

As an example of multi-agency collaboration, CDBs in Ireland emulate the international enthusiasm for inter-agency collaborative working, which has become something of an orthodoxy as a source of innovation and value for the delivery of public services. Yet the reality on the ground is often much more problematic and poor at adding value than the claims suggest and this has certainly been the experience of CDBs (Indecon, 2008). This has been well recognized, explored and theorized by such as Bardach (2001), Huxham and Vangen (2005), Keast *et al.* (2007), May and Winter (2007) and Sullivan and Skelcher (2002), highlighting the role of trust, power, language, governance, leadership and clarity of shared outcomes in explaining the extent to which collaborative working is facilitated or frustrated. Less attention has been paid to the role of institutional context on shaping local behaviours that contribute to the success or otherwise of collaborations. The intention of this empirical article is to speak to that gap and to advance scholarly and policy interest in the relationship between local collaborative action and structural context.

This article derives from a three-year action research study into local economic strategy-making by the economic strategy panel of the CDB in one region of Ireland. Dissatisfaction, lack of trust and asymmetrical power were major themes in the study, but in this article we particularly document how many of the frustrations voiced by participants with this local collaboration can be viewed within a theoretical perspective that conceptualizes individual agency as embedded in institutional rules, custom and regulation. Bryson *et al.* (2006) maintain that part of the intellectual challenge of studying cross-sector collaboration is blending multiple theoretical and research perspectives. In this article, we align ourselves with a fast growing body of literature in institutional studies which explores the interplay of structure and agency in an effort to explain institutional change and the role of actors and action in the creation or transformation of institutions despite pressures towards stasis (Battilana *et al.*, 2009; Garud *et al.*, 2007). The rationale for writing this article results from our own search for conceptual ideas to make sense of the early findings of the local study. Initially, literatures were reviewed on collaborative working, networks, inter-professional working and inter-agency working. However, separately we were also working with literature on structure and agency in institutional change and the policy process. We observed very minimal overlap of literatures. Systematically, we have run multiple

searches in the databases Emerald Fulltext, Ebsco and CINAHL combining the search terms collaboration/institutional; inter-organization/institutional; governance/collaboration/institutional within author abstracts and key words. Each search produced only single figure results. We therefore concluded it was worth sharing the insights we gained from the combined literatures.

The article is structured as follows. We first define the focus of our study, collaboration and relate our research question to three strands of literature that offer explanation for collaborative frustration and failure, namely, literature on collaborative working, collaboration or network governance and the limited work drawing from institutional theory to explore links between institutional context and local agency. Next, we outline core ideas from institutional theory which we suggest can contribute to a wider analysis of collaborative frustration. Following this we describe the methodology and research site, followed by the findings. These are organized to show how boundary reinforcing or anti-collaborative behaviours from local actors emerge in ways that can be explained by their institutional embeddedness in relation to their central government funding departments. Finally, a discussion and a conclusion highlight the potential of a structure-agency perspective on understanding frustration in collaborative-working as well as discussing implications for policy and practice. Because our findings emerged inductively from the data, and are based on a single case study in one country, that is particularly centralized in its relations between central government and service delivery organizations, the resulting propositions are tentative and require future exploration, a theme we address in the conclusion.

INTER-ORGANIZATIONAL COLLABORATION IN PUBLIC SERVICES

A joined-up approach to public policy issues and service delivery is almost universally espoused and it is unquestionable that many 'wicked' issues continue to challenge public services, without respect for organizational and professional boundaries. Nevertheless, the term collaborative working continues to take varying meanings, both in theory and in practice. According to O'Leary and Bingham (2007), collaborative public management can be defined as

a concept that describes the process of facilitating and operating in multi-organizational arrangements to solve problems that cannot be solved or easily solved by single organizations. Collaborative means to co-labour, to co-operate to achieve common goals, working across boundaries in multisector relationships. Cooperation is based on the value of reciprocity. (O'Leary and Bingham, 2007: 7)

For Bryson et al. (2006: 44), cross-sector collaboration is 'the linking or sharing of information, resources, activities, and capabilities by organizations in two or more sectors to achieve jointly an outcome that could not be achieved by organizations in one sector separately.'

A number of commentators offer a spectrum to categorize the extent of engagement between partners, from simply being information exchange, to adjustment of members' activities, resource sharing through to full synergistic enhanced capacity (Himmelman, 1996; Keast *et al.*, 2009; Rourke, 2007). For Keast *et al.* (2009: 7), a distinction can be made across a range between co-operation, a loose connection for sharing information, expertise and mutual support; co-ordination, where partners work in closer relationships to align resources and effort towards agreed shared goals and collaboration, characterized by strong and highly interdependent relationships through which partners make systemic changes to the ways they work, developing integrated strategies and sharing collective purpose. Inter-agency collaborative-working requires people to work across organizational boundaries, but from this categorization it is clear that such boundaries can vary, from simply knowledge boundaries in the case of co-operation to full collaboration across boundaries of mission, resources, capacity, responsibility and accountability (Kettl, 2006), as well as geographical space.

Why do public service organizations collaborate? At best they adopt a cooperative strategy because their leaders recognize this will produce a collaborative advantage (Huxham, 1996), delivering better results for the clients, customers or citizens, which would not be met if the organization worked on its own, what Sullivan and Skelcher (2002) term the optimistic view of collaboration. However, the pessimistic view (Sullivan and Skelcher, 2002) identifies that coercion may be the key driver to collaborative working, as governments and foundations insist that funding recipients collaborate, even if they have little evidence that it will work (Barringer and Harrison 2000). Huxham and Vangen (2005: 2) also highlight the downsides of inter-agency collaboration, describing collaborative inertia, 'a world filled with frustrations . . . there is a lot of evidence that many collaborations make slow progress and that others die without achieving anything.' It is this latter scenario we refer to when using the term collaborative frustration.

POLICY CONTEXT FOR THIS STUDY: IRELAND'S COUNTY AND CITY DEVELOPMENT BOARDS – AN EXAMPLE OF COLLABORATION POLICY

County and CDBs were established in each of the thirty-four County and City Councils across Ireland in 2000, as a government policy designed to achieve better integration of public and local service delivery. They comprise representatives from the four key sectors of local government, local development, social partners¹ and state agencies,² typically with around twenty-eight members (see Table 1).

The core function of the Boards was to draw up and oversee the implementation of an agreed 'Shared Vision' or Strategy for how their respective county or city is to develop economically, socially and culturally over a ten-year horizon, and what actions are needed to achieve this. 'Shared' reflects the intention that this vision is to be agreed between all the individual organizations on the local CDB. CDBs have no direct

Table 1: Typical membership of CDBs and their respective Central Government Funding Department (at 2010)

<i>Sector and typical no.</i>	<i>CDB members</i>	<i>Central Government Funding Department</i>
Local Government, 7	Strategic Policy Committee Chairs Cathaoirleach/Mayor County/City Manager Town Representative	Department of Environment, Community and Local Government
Local Development Agencies, 6 (2 each)	County/City Enterprise Board LEADER Groups (<i>national rural development network</i>) Partnership Companies and Community Groups	Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation Department of Environment, Community and Local Government Department of Environment, Community and Local Government
State Agencies, 10	HSE (<i>Health Service Executive</i>) FÁS (<i>Irish employment authority</i>) Teagasc (<i>Irish agriculture and food development authority</i>) An Garda Síochána (<i>police</i>) Vocational Education Committee Department of Education Regional Office County/City Childcare Committee Enterprise Ireland (<i>government agency supporting business</i>) IDA (<i>Industrial development authority</i>) Regional Tourism Organizations Department of Social Protection Regional Officer Shannon Development and/or Údarás na Gaeltachta (<i>agency for economic, social and cultural development of Irish speaking regions</i>)	Department of Health Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Food Department of Justice and Equality Department of Education and Skills Department of Education and Skills Department of Children and Youth Affairs Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation Department of Transport, Tourism and Sport Department of Social Protection Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation Department of Arts, Heritage and the Gaeltacht
Social Partners, 5	Employers and Business Organizations Trade Unions Agricultural and Farming Organizations Community and Voluntary Organizations (two members)	– – Department of Environment, Community and Local Government
Totals	Twenty-eight (<i>typically</i>)	Ten

executive powers, limited statutory powers and limited financial or other resources. Initially an ‘interdepartmental task force’ was established to provide coordination at central government level; however, this ceased to operate by the mid 2000s and was not substituted by any other process.

CDBs typically formed specialist committees to work on each of the strategy areas, and it is one such Economic Strategy Panel which is the focus of this study, henceforth referred to as ESP. This had eleven members, two private sector and nine public sector or semi-state bodies, funded in total by four different central government departments, as illustrated in Table 2. The ESP role is defined as ‘to strategically stimulate the enterprise and economic development in the county’ by working ‘collaboratively to develop collective actions that could not be implemented by any one agency acting alone.’ Members ‘will benefit by helping each other, sharing information and resources in a collective manner’.

Table 2: Membership of Economic Strategy Panel (ESP) and their respective Central Government Funding Department (at 2010)

<i>Sector and typical no.</i>	<i>CDB members</i>	<i>Central Government Funding Department</i>
Local Government, 1	County Manager	Department of Environment, Community and Local Government
Local Development Agencies, 2	County Enterprise Board LEADER Group (<i>national rural development network</i>)	Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation (<i>previously Department of Enterprise Trade and Employment</i>) Department of Environment, Community and Local Government
State Agencies, 6	FÁS (<i>Irish employment authority</i>) Third-level education institution Enterprise Ireland (<i>government agency supporting business</i>) IDA (<i>Industrial development authority</i>) Shannon Development Údarás na Gaeltachta (<i>agency for economic, social and cultural development of Irish speaking regions</i>)	Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation Department of Education and Skills Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation Department of Jobs, Enterprise and Innovation Department of Arts, Heritage and the Gaeltacht (<i>previously Department of Rural and Gaeltacht Affairs</i>)
Social Partners, 2	IBEC (<i>Irish Business and Employers Confederation</i>) Chamber of Commerce	Private sector Private sector
Totals	Eleven	Four

In the terms outlined above, CDBs can be categorized as a pessimistic collaboration, the coercive result of a central government policy directive. In Keast *et al.*'s (2009) typology ESP lay somewhere on the spectrum between co-operation and co-ordination.

EXPLANATIONS FOR COLLABORATIVE FAILURE – AGENCY, STRUCTURE AND AGENCY/STRUCTURE INTERPLAY

In the opening of this article, we said we align ourselves with a fast growing body of literature which explores the interplay of structure and agency. What do we mean by this? The traditional and enduring structure-agency debate polarizes analysis of human behaviour and decision-making between, on the one hand, the argument that they are the result of agency, the ability or capacity of actors to act consciously and make their own choices, and on the other hand, explanations that emphasize the role of social structures in shaping and delimiting individual agency (Berger and Luckman, 1966; Bourdieu, 1977, 1990; DiMaggio and Powell, 1983; Meyer and Rowan, 1977). This is simplifying the debate, but we want to start from here, in order to make the argument that institutional theory can add to the insights of collaborative management and governance. We will demonstrate this by comparing explanations for collaborative failure that emphasize agency, structure and the interplay of these.

Research and theorizing of collaborative failure has highlighted a number of key contributory factors. In practice, collaboration with others who have differing organizational cultural norms, values, priorities and systems is not straightforward. Pessimistic reasons for collaborating have an impact on participants' engagement, energy and commitment. Mandell and Steelman (2003) have argued that failure can often be attributed to the inappropriate form of collaboration chosen for the intended outcomes, orientation and relative power of members and type of issue. Barriers to effective collaboration have been found to include personal agendas, individual politicking, power imbalance, low trust, contradictory goals, poor managerial relationships, geographical distances, cultural differences and 'collaborative thuggery' (Huxham and Vangen, 2005: 232), categorized as leadership that does not empower, involve or mobilize, but manipulates the collaborative agenda. Other writers also emphasize the importance of leadership, for example, Gibney and Murie (2008) indicate that improved systemic working is dependent on different thinking about leadership qualities and behaviours, as encapsulated by the term 'leadership of place'. Ospina and Saz-Carranza's (2010: 405) work highlights leadership that honours 'contradictory demands for both unity and diversity'. Others draw attention to the contribution of management across a collaboration or network (Huxham and Beech, 2003; Meyer, 1999; O'Leary and Bingham, 2007) and propose a distinctive set of capabilities required for collaborative leadership (Benington and Hartley, 2009; Sullivan *et al.*, 2012).

Structural explanations of collaborative success and failure have been developed through the lens of governance (Bryson *et al.*, 2006; Osborne, 2006; Provan and Kenis,

2007; Ansell and Gash, 2007), which, though used in varying ways 'is most often presented as an attempt to improve co-ordination between relatively dependent actors for the purpose of solving societal problems' (Klijn, 2008: 505), or 'the use of institutions and structures or authority and collaboration to allocate resources and to coordinate and control joint action across the network as a whole.' (Provan and Kenis, 2007: 231). Whilst there are various strands of governance literature, Klijn (2008), in his review of ten years of research on governance and governance networks in Europe, categorized three traditions of network research: policy networks, that focus on power and participation in decision making; governing networks, focused on horizontal connections between traditional institutions and governance networks, and inter-organizational service delivery and policy implementation, where the focus is inter-organizational coordination and methods to improve effectiveness. In relation to this typology, we suggest the literature on governance in collaboration is closest to the third tradition, in which 'structure' has predominantly been concerned with the roles and stratification amongst collaboration members.

Klijn (2008: 517) comments that 'networks are also generally considered as an organizational form in itself instead of a loosely coupled set of relations between the actors.' The focus is at the level of a whole network, what Powell *et al.* (2005) term the collective action; on co-ordination, control and management of those participating within a collaboration or network. For the governance approach, the unit of analysis is the network or collaboration. Within this there is an implicit assumption of rationality: if only we could get the right governance arrangement, the collaboration would function effectively; problems of trust, communication, power, etc. will be resolved. However, the approach lacks explanatory value when collaboration continues to be frustrating despite apparent attention to governance arrangements. It also does not illuminate the situation of overlapping institutional influences whereby local collaborative partners are part of multiple, overlapping fields.

Collaboration theory has elucidated the role of agency, in terms of trust, communication, leadership and has also focused on social relations and the structure of these within the collaboration, in terms of governance arrangements. However, even within much of the governance literature there is an implicit sense that these are subject to agency, in the sense that the ability to make the right choices over, say, roles and coordination, is within the control of local participants. However, as Meyer and Rowan (1977) argue, organizations do not adopt organizational structures and forms rationally but incorporate socially-mediated (institutionalized) structures to achieve legitimacy, without necessarily paying regard to the impact on efficiency. Scharpf (1997: 38) talks of actors' choices within a network as being structured by a system of rules that are 'activated by the actors in separate games', although it may well be that the rules are not always clear or fully known by participants. When 'games' cover more than one network or institution, with their differing rules, this can explain why difficulties arise.

STRUCTURING AGENCY – INSIGHTS FROM INSTITUTIONAL THEORY

Writers on collaborative governance do acknowledge impact from the central government or political/cultural context (Mandell and Steelman, 2003). However, despite the recognition in some of the literature on collaborative frustration in public services of the role of the external environment in which inter-agency collaborations are embedded, it has received far less attention than has the consideration of internal dynamics of collaborative arrangements. Far less theoretical or empirical attention has been devoted to the ways in which the institutional contexts of collaborative participants might shape their actions and behaviours with collaborative arrangements. Exceptions exist, for example, Bryson *et al.* (2006: 45) point out that 'the institutional environment is especially important because it includes broad systems of relationships across public jurisdictional areas that can directly affect the collaborative purpose, structure, and outcomes.' They draw attention to the ways in which 'changes in government policy often destabilize systems or alter resources in the policy fields in which networks are embedded and hence rearrange the structure of ties among members' (Bryson *et al.*, 2006: 49).

Context has also been recognized by other scholars, such as Hibbert and Huxham (2010: 533) who point out, 'even relatively small interorganizational collaborations. . . by their very nature normally span a number of social contexts, and action within all collaborations should therefore be seen as embedded within multiple networks of social relations'. Some have identified context as the source of conflicting values amongst collaborative partners, such as efficiency, accountability or participatory democracy and the extent to which members bring to cross-sector collaborations, what Bryson *et al.* (2006) term, competing institutional logics on the collaboration's process, structure or governance. Saz-Carranza and Serra's (2009) exploration of trust within private–public partnerships concluded sources of the identified cross-sector distrust are institutional: insufficient regulation and legislation, lack of business certification and low local government administrative capacity. Finally, Skelcher and Sullivan (2008: 768) proposed that 'understanding the possibilities and limitations of the structure–agency duality offers the basis for developing a more refined understanding of the performance of collaborative ventures'.

In the next section, we introduce the core institutional concepts we suggest can offer new insights to collaborative frustration, specifically divergent institutional change, embedded agency, institutional entrepreneurship, boundary spanning and path dependency. In this sense, the structure–agency interplay can be further elucidated.

In institutional theory, institutions are associated primarily with stability, setting out the rules and routines that constrain human action, the 'rules of the game'. Institutions are 'stable, valued and recurring patterns of behaviour' (Huntington, 1968). For Klijn and Koppenjan (2006: 143), 'institutions actually form the social infrastructure of our behaviour. . . They enable interactions, provide stability and certainty and form the basis on which actors' trust may be founded. At the same time they serve to 'codify'

previous (unequal) power relations, of common opinions and permitted discussions and may thus obstruct or hamper reforms'. Rules form the heart of institutions – they influence, guide and delimit the behaviour of actors.

It is our observation that the term 'institution' in much collaboration literature is used differently from the understanding offered by institutional theory. In our reading of the former the term is rarely defined and often appears used inter-changeably with 'organization'. By contrast, recent ideas from institutional theory conceive of institutionalization as a process (Blackler and Regan, 2006), which 'views organizations as social entities embedded in 'fields' of beliefs and conventions' (p1843). 'Field' is defined as a sphere of human activity, a context or setting, what Wacquant (2006) describes as 'distinct microcosms endowed with their own rules, regularities, and forms of authority'. In the context of this study, drawing on DiMaggio and Powell (1983) the CDB system can be conceptualized as an organizational field consisting of *suppliers* (organizations within a geographic region providing a direct local service), *service users* (clients), *regulatory agencies* (central government departments) and *other organizations that want to influence services* (e.g. local councillors). Key actors within this field are involved with each other and interact with each other in the shared purpose of positively affecting the local economy. The notion of a field extends conceptualization of a collaborative arrangement from the internal relations and organization of a local network, to the combined 'loosely coupled set of relations between the actors' (Klijn, 2008: 517), encompassing both the local level and central government. It brings into focus the wider arena of power relations between and across centre and local and encourages questioning of what processes of structuration (Giddens, 1984) are at play, who they benefit and what institutional logics (Reay and Hinings, 2009) are guiding and constraining local actors. Rather than focusing on the internal functioning of a collaboration, institutional theory, building on Meyer and Rowan (1977) and DiMaggio and Powell (1983) extends the attention to the shaping of individual actions by established institutional frameworks.

One of the insights of institutional theory is the notion of path dependencies, in the sense that within any particular institutional setting, past choices influence subsequent choices, to the point of what Tödling and Trippel (2004) describe as cognitive lock-in, or because the costs of adopting an alternative are or appear to be greater than keeping to the same path (Lowndes, 2005; Pierson, 2000). This process of institutionalized narrowing can limit the space of possibilities for change and create paths of dependence. Whilst some sources of constraint can be internal to an organization, such as cultural norms, policies and procedures, other influences derive externally, notably from governmental mandate, professional routines or market conditions. Having said this, institutional theory does not exclude path-breaking behaviour in certain circumstances. DiMaggio and Powell (1983) posited the role of 'institutional isomorphism', that is organizations' pursuit of political and institutional legitimacy. They identified three mechanisms for institutional isomorphism each of which can help explain how path-breaking behaviour might arise. These are coercive (pressures for conformity from

other organizations or society), mimetic (imitation of other successful organizations in the face of uncertainty) and normative isomorphism (generation of shared values through professionalization of education, socialization and networking across organizations). Dickenson and Glasby (2010) draw on ideas of isomorphism to explain the prevalence of partnership working despite the absence of evidence for its effectiveness in a particular context. They make reference to the coercive isomorphism that makes it a legal duty to collaborate when: 'the wider institutional context values partnership and imbues it with importance' (Dickenson and Glasby, 2010: 824).

In institutional theory, 'divergent change' describes 'changes that break the institutional status quo in a field of activity and thereby possibly contribute to the transforming existing institutions or creating new ones' (Battilana *et al.*, 2009: 67). In this sense, the policy of CDBs in Ireland can be seen as a divergent institutional change for organizations within the broad field of the Irish public services in that the requirement to make decisions and craft strategy in collaboration across organizational, resource and information boundaries was a departure from established practice in Irish service delivery organizations. As Reay and Hinings suggest,

the concepts of institutional logics, organizational fields and institutional change are tightly connected. Institutional logics are the organizing principles that shape the behaviour of field participants. Because they refer to a set of belief systems and associated practices, they define the content and meaning of institutions. Thus institutional logics provide a link between institutions and action, and are an important concept for understanding organizational fields. (Reay and Hinings, 2009: 631)

The interplay of structure with agency attempts to both account for the actors' embeddedness in their institutional environment and examine the conditions that may enable the emergence of 'institutional entrepreneurship' (Battilana *et al.*, 2009; DiMaggio, 1988; Garud *et al.*, 2007) understood as activities and leadership geared toward divergent change. The concept of institutional entrepreneurship is used to describe the actions of individuals or smaller organizations who express a vision of divergent change and act to leverage resources, mobilize allies, develop alliances, create cooperation and bridge political stakeholders across organizational, national and international boundaries to push for particular arrangements with regard to a policy interpretation. Institutional entrepreneurship may emerge under certain enabling conditions which include both the social position of the actor within the organizational field and field characteristics (Battilana *et al.*, 2009), examples of which may be technological innovation, social upheaval, economic crisis or, as was the case with CDBs in this study, regulatory changes in the form of new legislation.

This also introduces the notion of 'embedded agency' which refers to the tension between institutional determinism, the very essence of institutional theory, and agency, which posits that individuals and organizations have the ability for leadership and manoeuvre despite, or rather within, the constraints posed by institutional practices and

structures on their behaviour. In this sense, the latter constrain and enable, but do not wholly determine the choices of actors (Battilana *et al.*, 2009). Leca *et al.* (2008) ask 'how actors can become institutional entrepreneurs despite institutional pressures, and thereby resolve the paradox of embedded agency'. They argue that because they can seldom change institutions alone, institutional entrepreneurs must typically mobilize allies and develop alliances, particularly with key constituents such as highly embedded agents (Lawrence *et al.*, 2002), professionals and experts (Leca *et al.*, 2008).

Beckert offers one of the most integrated frameworks for making sense of collaborative frustration, interconnecting social networks, institutions and cognitive frameworks to acknowledge that 'agency in fields is structured by the influences that social forces exercise on the actors who populate the field. These forces consist of networks, the institutional rules prevalent in the field and cognitive frames structuring the perceptions of agents' (Beckert, 2010: 610). From this perspective, attention is focused on how actors' behaviour apparent within local inter-agency collaboration can be understood as shaped by the norms of their professional networks, the taken-for-granted thinking and the regulatory rules of their particular institutional context. This article aims to extend the empirical evidence in the area.

THE STUDY

The action research study on which this article is based was conducted by one of the authors as a participant within the economic strategy panel of one of the CDB organizations (henceforth referred to as ESP, see Table 2 for members).

In Coghlan and Brannick's (2009) terms, this was a pragmatic action research study in the sense that the research was initiated with the intention to explore and find ways to improve a pre-defined problematic situation, namely, that the collaboration was seen as under-delivering. Initiated by the researcher and her boss, the local authority CEO, the research study was undertaken overtly, with the knowledge of all participants. Research/intervention cycles included a number of key initiatives by ESP members that required collaboration between members, such as creation of shared promotional resources; development of a shared strategy and an internal review day.

An ethnographic approach dominated (Gray, 2009), in which much of the research material collected consisted of extensive observational notes and quotes recorded verbatim in the course of regular ESP and sub-group meetings, as this was the natural setting for the group (Lewin, 1946). Notes were also made from opportunistic conversations, for example, as might occur during a coffee break or corridor-talk. In addition, the researcher employed semi-structured interviews with all members, recorded and transcribed. These were in themselves recognized as an intervention (Schein, 1999) in the sense that the questions themselves brought particular themes to the interviewees' consciousness. These materials were complemented by a

systematically kept research journal, structured using Schein's Observation, Reaction, Judgement, Intervention (ORJI), framework (Schein, 1999). The resultant material was analysed though NVivo in two stages. Initial coding corresponded to dimensions from the reviewed literature associated with collaborative working, whilst the second stage of coding took a more grounded approach in the sense of taking themes that emerged from the data, but which were expressed in terms of additional reading, including embeddedness and boundary-spanning. Once coded, the analysis examined the data for connections and patterns. One of the patterns that emerged was the relationship between individual participants' actions and their institutional context (see Table 3 for codes and themes that have informed this article).

In order to ascertain whether these themes within this particular CDB study were unique or if they were shared by CDBs elsewhere in the country we looked at secondary data in the form of a national review of CDBs (Indecon, 2008). Commissioned in 2005 by the Minister for Environment, Heritage and Local Government and concluded in 2008, this review of the thirty-four CDBs across Ireland was undertaken by consultants, Indecon, with data collected in the form of CDB strategy documents, reports of actions taken, interviews with Directors of Service and County/City Managers, as well as a range of other individuals and organizations including those in the voluntary and community sectors. No data were included in this study from central government actors, either civil servants or politicians.

FINDINGS

A consistent theme emerging from this study is the high level of frustration amongst participants at not achieving their expectations from the collaboration. Their own

Table 3: Codes and themes informing this article

<i>Initial coding</i>	<i>Codes (emergent)</i>	<i>Thematic findings</i>
Participant perceptions of collaboration	Boundary spanning	Lack of central coordination
	Embeddedness	Individual organization agendas
Motives for participation	Social position	
	Accountability	Inter-agency competition
Power		Centre-local accountability relationships
		The primary boundary
Trust		
Leadership		
Structure		
Context		
Behaviours		

explanations for this are dominated by negative perceptions expressed by many participants about each other's apparent level of commitment, engagement, mutual trust and willingness to share information or resources. This echoes the common themes discussed in the literature on inter-agency collaborative working, as highlighted above, and it is not the intention of this article to dwell on these already-established agentic factors. A second dominant theme which reinforces the literature is the role of leadership. However, a key prompt to our wider reading was a sense that if the themes of the local study were repeated thirty-four times across the country they could not all be explained in terms of agency. In the remainder of this article, we want to explore other themes that emerged from the analysis which relate to institutional context, which we categorize as:

- 1 Lack of central coordination
- 2 Individual organization agendas
- 3 Inter-agency competition
- 4 Centre-local accountability relationships
- 5 The primary boundary

We now elaborate on each of these.

Lack of central coordination

Criticism was made of central government by several participants for a lack of coordination that, they say, is affecting the work of local and regional inter-agency collaborations. For example, one member explains that a lack of coordination between the Department of Rural and Gaeltacht Affairs and the Department of the Enterprise Trade and Employment 'is causing great consternation countrywide. . . . It's causing very bad. . . , bad feeling between County Enterprise Boards and Partnerships'.

Boundary spanning across central government departments was criticized compared to the expectation placed on the County Council

to get various agencies around the table and broker, mediate and negotiate a common consensus, an overall vision, action plan and with a funding alignment; something that the centre failed to do . . . Central government are expecting county administration to lead out collaboration while there seems to be little collaboration occurring at national level among national departments, coupled with this there are no special budgets aligned for such collaborations, or training for members.

In the local study at the centre of this article, public bodies are funded by and accountable to four different central government departments. The Civil Service in Ireland is highly silo-ised. Civil servants often start and forge a career within one department (for example, Revenue, Social Protection and Education). At senior levels

it is impossible to transfer, for example, from Assistant Secretary General of one department to the equivalent or to Secretary General of another. Irish public services are also highly agencified, delivered locally (according to 2007 figures) through almost 250 quangos in addition to elected local authorities (MacCarthaigh, 2007). Table 1 gives just some examples of such agencies. Career movement between state agencies is rare and difficult, meaning that most employees do not have experience across a range of areas. Similar barriers to career trajectories have also been true across levels of public service, for example, between local and central government. Financially, each central Department reports in the Oireachtas (parliament) to their respective Minister and data sharing practice and systems across Departments is poor.

Individual organization agendas

Over the course of the study, research notes recorded low attendance at meetings, refusal by some individuals to commit their organization's resources to proposed joint initiatives, advocacy of pet projects and personal agendas, which led to the question of what motivated members to collaborate on the CDB. When asked directly their motives generally reflected a pessimist perspective (Sullivan and Skelcher, 2002). There is a statutory obligation for member organizations to be represented on the CDB and its sub-groups such as ESP, as noted by one individual: 'We're on them because we have to be...'. Not uncommonly individuals were seen to be driven by opportunity to advance their own organization, as illustrated by the following comment: 'I find it particularly frustrating at times dealing with a lot of agencies and individuals, that their own motivation wouldn't be driven by the collective agenda, it would be driven more by the agency agenda.' Another observed: 'There seems to be a *'mé féiner'* [Irish term for someone who puts their own interests first] benefit from a collective investment'. However, individuals did not seem to behave as true pessimists, in Sullivan and Skelcher's (2002) definition, in that they did not overtly try to take advantage of each other. More prevalent was seizing opportunities to promote themselves or protect their organization in contradiction to the pursuit of an overall objective of collaborating for the shared purpose of economic development of the county.

Inter-agency competition

Whilst trust and levels of information-sharing were not particularly high at the beginning of the study, a sense of decreasing trust and sharing amongst participants has been observed since 2009. In one instance an ESP member, whose organization, with a national remit, had been involved in a successful unemployment initiative, was asked about it by others from the ESP because they were keen to replicate in the county.

When the member was invited directly to explain the project, they left other members perplexed when they would neither provide the information nor agree to find out and bring information back to the next meeting, saying 'if you want to know, you should be checking it out'.

Interviews with participants suggested that the decline in trust could be attributed to the radical cuts confronting public services across Ireland (McCarthy, 2009). For example, the LEADER groups, County Enterprise Board and Udarás na Gaeltachta (UnG) all have targets to meet for numbers of new micro-business start-ups initiated and numbers of entrepreneurs trained. Yet within the county of this study, as elsewhere, they are fishing in the same pool, competing for the same clientele. In an environment where there are prospects that one or more of these bodies might disappear or be merged with another, individuals and agencies are being positioned in competition for the roles that might remain by their institutional context.

Centre-local accountability relationships

CDB policy originated from the Department of Environment and Local Government (known at the time of writing as the Department of Environment, Community & Local Government), the Irish central government department that 'oversees the operation of the local government system and implement[s] policy in relation to local government structures, functions, human resources and financing' (<http://www.environ.ie/en/LocalGovernment/27-11-11>).

As Table 2 illustrates, the CDB economic strategy panel at the centre of this study had eleven members, accountable to four different central government departments.

The study found that local collaboration received little or no priority from many of these departments. Performance management of agencies by Departments does not necessarily integrate local collaboration. For example, some individuals in this study report that the central government department to whom their agency was accountable would not include time spent contributing to the CDBs within their workload count. This is despite the contradictory requirement within CDB policy for local government to involve those same local agencies in CDB collaboration.

Participants gave examples of ways in which the performance and accountability arrangements of their organization to their respective government funding department did not encourage collaboration in the ESP. Two organizations, IDA and UnG have national remits and targets and no specific county targets. They do not need to participate in ESP in order to meet their performance targets and within the national workplans of one of them, as prepared for their respective government department, there is no time scheduled for inter-agency collaboration. Similarly, another member from one of the state agencies described how he cannot put inter-agency hours down on his timesheet. In this sense, central rules are disincentivising collaboration.

The primary boundary

Related to the above theme, there is a sense that participants are clear as to which are the primary boundaries which they should span, and these are not those across the other agencies that make up the ESP. The priority of keeping on good terms with the particular civil servants through which your organization was funded and to whom you reported was captured up by one of the local study participants, when explaining their own actions: 'The only problem there is you have a lifelong relationship with the Department in terms of getting work done. And if you get off side of that it could constrain the future'.

National study

As mentioned earlier, in order to ascertain whether these themes within this particular CDB study were unique or if they were shared by CDBs elsewhere in the country we looked at secondary data in the form of a national review of CDBs (Indecon, 2008). This national review echoes the identification of institutional context and centre-local relations as a constraint on local collaborative working. One respondent notes a 'lack of communication across government departments at national level' (Indecon, 2008: 43) whilst another observes:

Notwithstanding the excellent support of the Policy Division of the Department of Environment and Local Government, it was clear that other departments were not committed with consequent results e.g. lack of flexibility for use of resources at county level, lack of real consultation with CDB on matters of importance. (Indecon, 2008 42)

Institutionally, there is 'no requirement for member organizations to report to their parent Government Department or National Social Partner Forum' (Indecon, 2008: 42) and 'furthermore interagency co-operation/collaboration is not rewarded either for the individual board member of the parent organization' (Indecon, 2008: 48).

The value of this national study is to show that the experiences of participants in the main, local study, are not isolated and, in being echoed elsewhere in the country, cannot be attributed purely to actions and behaviours of individuals within the local collaboration. The next section discusses how these themes of local-centre relations can be made sense of drawing from institutional concepts.

DISCUSSION: LINKING LOCAL FRUSTRATION WITH INSTITUTIONAL CONTEXT

In this study, local actions that undermine trust and discourage sharing are considered within their institutional context. We look to insights from institutional theory to help

explain participants' frustration with collaborative working at the local level. We want to argue that collaboration can be extended by the concept of field because it illuminates the inter-relationship between structure and agency. We argue that a closer reading of new institutional literature has more to offer understanding of collaborative dysfunction.

Divergent change and sources of stability

The CDB policy can be described as a divergent change (Battilana *et al.*, 2009), in that it broke with existing conventions, requiring people to collaborate across organizational, discipline and information boundaries. In that the institutional field (as illustrated in Table 1) included not only twenty-eight bodies operating within any single county or city, but also the civil servants and ministers of ten central government departments, it was a divergent change to the whole central-local field, not simply for the frontline service-providing organizations.

Institutional theory illuminates the importance of institutional factors in creating a normative environment for collaboration or indeed for non-collaboration (Skelcher and Sullivan, 2008). However, the extent to which collaborative-working becomes embedded depends on the institutional logics or the logics of appropriate behaviour (March and Olsen, 1989) applying to each collaboration member. The eleven organizations involved in the ESP of this study (see Table 2 above) are each shaped by rules that emanate from the institutions of central government, such as the traditions of financial reporting of each government department and the performance frameworks. As this study found, routinized rules and norms for work planning and the use of time differed across central government departments. Local organizations are to a greater or lesser extent, embedded in the institutional frameworks in which they operate, but this study suggests that the ESP collaboration at least, is dominated by highly embedded agents, whose actions are shaped by competing institutional logics. The idea of logics of appropriateness can help explain the persistence of particular ways of doing things by some local organization members that undermine or resist collaborative practice despite the fact CDBs are a statutory way of working.

Path-breaking behaviour

As discussed earlier, institutional theory does allow for path-breaking behaviour in certain circumstances, and in relation to collaborative-frustration in this study we can consider the strength of institutional conditions which reinforced or stimulated this. Thinking first of the three mechanisms of 'institutional isomorphism' (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983), that is organization's pursuit of political and institutional legitimacy, we suggest that none of them was strong. Some coercive pressure exists on all the CDB

member organizations in that there is a statutory obligation to be represented. However, the absence of integrating collaborative work within the targets or performance monitoring of most CDB member organizations and the absence of linking resources to engage collaboratively (Skelcher *et al.*, 2012) can be seen as weak coercive pressure to really stimulate collaboration, as distinct from cooperating (in Keast *et al.*'s (2009) terms). In this study, none of the member organizations was held up as a model of collaborative behaviour. Also, as the national review of CDBs indicates, frustration with this collaborative arrangement was nationwide, from which we suggest the mimetic mechanism was limited in that there were no highly successful direct peers to imitate. Normative isomorphism, the power of shared values and their transmission across members from different sectors, was observed through the action research study, and members were asked explicitly what their motives for engaging in EPS were. The extent of shared values was not strong, with one indication being the varying motivations members gave for engaging in the EPS collaboration. Three of the eleven said the purpose was mutual benefit, five saw the purpose as to achieve outputs that could not be achieved by their agency alone, two believed the motive was to work in partnership and one saw the purpose as 'to work together in concert so that common objectives from which none individually benefit'.

Institutional theory suggests that path-breaking behaviour or implementation of divergent change depends largely on the presence of one or more institutional entrepreneurs who are willing and able to bring along reluctant implementers, gaining legitimacy for the project (Battilana *et al.*, 2009). In the CDB study, barriers were identified to institutional entrepreneurship at the local level in the sense that even where individuals and agencies might want to deviate from the normative pressures imposed by their respective central Government departments or national agencies, they were tempered by a concern to keep a good long-term relationship with that department. This echoes the argument that the extent of local distinctiveness relates to the degree of autonomy and diversity that higher levels of government will tolerate (Leadbeater and Goss, 1998; Williams, 2002). There will be no 'rule breakers' or mavericks at local level in a field with tight central control. In other words, the pattern of cross boundary working locally will mirror that of the centre. As observed in this local study and as reported in the national study, there is little evidence of institutional entrepreneurship or boundary spanning at central government level, in the sense of activities and leadership designed to create cooperation and bridge boundaries across central government departments.

Embedded agency

The paradox of embedded agency recognizes a tension between agency, which posits that individuals and organizations have the ability for leadership and manoeuvre and the constraints posed by institutional practices and structures on their behaviour. An

indication from this study is that agents in the wider field of EPS were too embedded. According to ideas of embedded agency, central government players, because of their high status, are deeply embedded in the taken for granted rules and norms of their institutional setting, thus are less likely to make changes without external or internal jolts (Greenwood and Suddaby, 2006). This helps make sense of actions of individuals from differing CDB member agencies, whereby, as Beckert puts it ‘the relative force of actors is anchored in regulative institutional rules which allow and support certain types of behaviour while discouraging others’ (Beckert, 2010: 610). In the context of institutional inertia and poor boundary-spanning at the centre, there is effective sanctioning of non-collaborative behaviours at the local level.

At the same time, given that the CDB policy can be described as a divergent change, in that it broke with existing conventions, institutional theory would suggest it was reasonable to expect that it would not be a change readily embraced by groups with dissenting interests or by individuals within affected organizations, who have set ways, in the sense of the habitual nature of much of public servants’ practices, which often prove resilient even in the face of new regulations and guidelines and constitute one of the basic institutional pressures toward stasis (Battilana *et al.*, 2009). In other words, to be successful CDB policy at the local level required a disruption to the habitual practices of central government departments as much as it did to those of local organizations.

CONCLUSION AND IMPLICATIONS

This study of collaboration in the context of regional economic strategy-making in Ireland in one sense reports a familiar theme of frustration amongst local partners with one another and the difficult process of attempting to collaborate. Our findings are, of course, limited to one in-depth empirical study and in a particularly centralized context; however, they are substantiated by findings from the national review. If we only analysed dynamics of the local collaboration in terms of the local patterns of inter-relationships and the extent of trust, leadership, power-sharing or common objectives, important though these are, our conclusions would end at proposals for attention to governance arrangements to clarify roles and address power relations, so as to give trust a chance to build. We might also make recommendations for a development intervention to cultivate collaborative management capabilities. We do not diminish the significance of these insights on collaborative relationships; however, our conclusion is that a focus on agency alone is not adequate for explaining the frustrations of collaborative arrangements.

Our findings suggest that illumination of collaborative working can be enhanced by conceptualizing the CDB collaboration policy as a field that encompasses not only the local CDB members, but the wider combined institutional field of central government departments in addition to local organizations. Once this view is taken it opens up the analysis to consider how the behaviour of local actors may be shaped by the socialization

and regulation of their institutional context. Institutional theory tells us that individual and organization actions at local level are likely to be guided and constrained by the institutional logics of which they are a member, to be aligned with paths that are structured by the funding and performance management arrangements of the centre, in other words the central government departments. Such path dependency creates a powerful cycle of self-reinforcing activity, whereby members of a local body that reports to a particular government department or is the regional branch of a particular state agency, will tend to act in ways that are consistent with the institutional logics of that parent department. They will typically forgo alternatives and often have little choice when what is involved relates to reporting, monitoring, information, work planning and accounting systems. In this sense, as deeply embedded agents, there are institutional factors that enable and constrain individuals in the way they engage with CDB collaboration locally.

In this particular study, it seems the frustrations with non-collaborative behaviours within the local collaboration cannot just be attributed to the agency of local actors or the absence of boundary-spanning behaviours amongst these local members, even though this may be the case. A fuller picture is only achieved by also questioning the extent of boundary-spanning behaviours centrally. Institutional theory illuminates the question of the beliefs and conventions, the differing rules and logics that emanate from each central government department to create a framework for their respective CDB member organizations, that in differing create a framework for the collaboration full of contradictory rules. In such a context, where a local collaboration traverses several institutions, attention to the inter-relations of individuals or to local network governance will not be sufficient to achieve effective collaboration. This is what we mean by the interplay of structure and agency.

A number of implications flow from these conclusions. Given the particularly centralized context of Irish government and public services, they may not be startling and may not translate to other jurisdictions, where local collaborations have much greater delegated authority. However, we suggest it is likely they have relevance to other small centralized countries. In brief, we suggest there are three main implications: for scoping policy reviews at a field level, for integration mechanisms at central government level and for further research, as we now outline.

Policy reviews – evaluate the wider institutional field not just the local ‘implementers’

Policy studies has been well critiqued for its domination by a rational planning model of decision-making, in which a linear sequence of stages from problem identification to implementation is assumed, and implementation is perceived as an administrative process (Fischer, 2003), devoid of values (Hajer, 2003), interests or emotion (Wagenaar and Cook, 2003). From education, to environment, poverty and language

policy (Shohamy, 2006), people have been considered either as those who have policy done to them or as shadowy resisters (Ball, 1997). This article reinforces the view that policies are not merely implemented, but are actually shaped on the ground (Ball, 1997; Peck and 6, 2006). Accordingly, people here, are not the passive receivers of policies or the vague resisters once depicted in research accounts, referring to public body practitioners (Shohamy, 2006), but are social actors who can exercise agency, as they actively engage in the planning, interpretation, modification and/or (selective) implementation of policy, in accordance with existing institutional practices, external pressures and individual preferences, even as they act within constraints imposed by organizational structures (Battilana *et al.*, 2009) or in path dependent ways (Lowndes, 2005).

To improve the success and effectiveness of collaborative arrangements, such as CDBs in Ireland, evaluations must look beyond the assumption that the barriers to collaboration are primarily ones of individual agency at the local level, in other words that it is the individual choices, actions, leadership skills or their lack which determine the success or otherwise of local collaboration. Only if the policy field is conceptualized as one that combines the centre and local, can it be understood that the divergent change requiring cross boundary working affects central government departments not only local organizations. To adopt this perspective means that evaluation should be of the entire field and not narrowly about the agency of frontline local bodies.

Central government integration mechanisms

An implication for practice is that any calls for greater collaboration at a local level will produce very limited effects without a simultaneous scrutiny of cross-boundary working at the centre. From this study alone, it is too early to make definitive recommendations as to the mechanisms for enhancing boundary spanning and institutional entrepreneurship at central government level. This is an area requiring further examination.

Finally, we have argued for the importance of context and it may be that the conclusions from this study do not relate directly to collaboration policy in a differing context, for example, to other countries where collaborating partners do not report back to so many different funding departments or where they are managed with much greater decentralization arrangements. Additional research to explore different policy contexts is required to further confirm or question the insights we have offered. For now, we offer a contribution to what Skelcher and Sullivan (2008) term a duality of structure and agency – the way in which ideas and institutions enable and constrain individual activity.

Further research

As an action research study focused on local collaboration, the scope did not encompass close examination of behaviours by actors within and across central government.

Therefore, a final implication we identify is the value of advancing our understanding of the interplay of structure and agency through studying the wider institutional field with an integrated framework, such as Beckert's (2010) interconnection of social networks, institutions and cognitive frameworks so as to explore how agency in fields is structured by the influences that social forces exercise on the actors involved.

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NOTES

- 1 *Social partners* refers to national bodies such as trade unions, employer associations such as IBEC, community and voluntary bodies.
- 2 *State agencies* include such bodies as Enterprise Ireland, regional tourism organizations and An Garda Síochána (police).

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